21.11.4 Preventive measures for Cancer

Cancer control programmes should focus on primary prevention and early detection.

To prevent lung cancer tobacco smoking is to be avoided and protective measures to be taken against exposure to toxic pollutants of industries. Excessive exposure to radiation is to be avoided to prevent skin cancer.

21.12 AIDS (Acquired Immunedeficiency Syndrome)

AIDS is a severe viral disease and caused by Human Immunodeficiency Virus (HIV). It is a condition in which immune system fails and **suppress the body's disease fighting mechanism**. They **attack the lymphocytes** and the affected individual is prone to infectious diseases.



Dr. Suniti Solomon, pioneered HIV research and treatment in India. She set up the first voluntary testing and counselling centre and an AIDS Research group in Chennai during 80's. Her team was the first to document evidence of HIV infection in India in 1985 (First Indian AIDS patient in Chennai).

21.12.1 Transmission of HIV

AIDS virus has been found in urine, tears, saliva, breast milk and vaginal secretions. The virus is transmitted by an infected patient who comes in contact with blood of a healthy person. HIV/AIDS is not transmitted by touch or any physical contact. It spreads through contact of body fluids or blood.

HIV is transmitted generally by

(i) Sexual contact with infected person

(ii) Use of contaminated needles or syringes especially in case of intravenous drug abusers

(iii) By transfusion of contaminated / infected blood or blood products

(iv) From infected mother to her child through placenta.

21.12.2 Symptoms and Treatment of AIDS

Symptoms: Infected individuals become immunodeficient. The person becomes more susceptible to viral, bacterial, protozoan and fungal infections. Swelling of lymph nodes, damage to brain, loss of memory, lack of appetite and weight loss, fever, chronic diarrhoea, cough, lethargy, pharyngitis, nausea and headache.

Diagnosis: The presence of HIV virus can be confirmed by **Western Blot** analysis or **Enzyme Linked Immunosorbent Assay** (ELISA)

Treatment: Anti-retroviral drugs and immunostimulative therapy can prolong the life of the infected person.

21.12.3 Prevention and Control of AIDS

The following steps may help in controlling and prevent the spreading of HIV infection

(i) Screening of blood from blood banks for HIV before transfusion.

(ii) Ensuring the use of disposable needles and syringes in hospitals and clinics.

(iii) Advocating safe sex and advantages of using condoms.

(iv) Creating awareness campaign and educating people on the consequences of AIDS.

(v) Persons with HIV/AIDS should not be isolated from the family and society.



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